

High-Speed Innovation with Distributed Leadership

It is uncommon, rather impossible, that one person has all the skills and talent to create success. Chances of success often increase with diverse perspectives and expertise of many. But the selection of person is also crucial.

If you look carefully at the current organisational mix, you will see an exciting emerging trend. Most companies now have at least three different generations in their employee mix. It is interesting because each of these generations looks at management principles and leadership quite differently.

So, the question is, with such a wide mix of talent, ideologies, thinking, and operating styles, how do you ensure high-speed innovation?

I have rarely seen an employee that wants to be told what to do. Instead, most of them want leaders to trust them for being capable of doing the right thing. And, from that perspective, most of the management principles from the past are not applicable anymore. When we think of a progressive organisation and innovation, these factors need to be accounted for.

The challenge

Volatility in the environment and ecosystem at various levels is increasing. Uncertainties are mounting and are increasingly becoming routine in business environments.



A volatile environment needs decisiveness. It needs a clear vision and curiosity to deal with it. Having a broad knowledge base can be helpful.

Dealing with uncertainty demands diversity and courage in teams. You need people bringing different perspectives and showing strong bias for action.

Now the challenge is, for most of the businesses, at least the ones I have seen, decision-making points are the major bottlenecks. They impede agility. It means they have an adverse impact in a volatile and uncertain environment.

If your business fails to remove these bottlenecks quickly and efficiently, survival could be a challenge soon. Pandemic has shown everyone a small demo of what can happen and

how the smallest bottleneck can create dire situations.

Incumbent models of leadership emphasize compliance and resource distribution. They are mostly directive and hierarchical. However, with the new multi-generational employee-mix, they need an overhaul.

A new perspective

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That is where my proposed new leadership model will come in handy—the distributed leadership, that is, democratised decision-making at a cross-functional level.